2023 NORDES

HOMEWORK: THE POLITICS OF PARTICIPATORY DESIGN IN DISTRIBUTED CONTEXTS

ALICIA SMEDBERG
MALMÖ UNIVERSITY
ALICIA.SMEDBERG@MAU.SE

JENS PORTISON-HYLANDER
STATENS VÄG- OCH TRANSPORTFORSKNINGSINSITUT (VTI)
JENS.HYLANDER@VTI.SE

ABSTRACT

This paper examines the evolving nature of participatory design as it shifts from co-located, real-time engagements to asynchronous, delegated participation—a transformation conceptualized here as *homework*. Through two case studies—a toolkit for activist self-organization and a workbook-based remote design process—the paper explores how participation, when structured as homework, redistributes agency, responsibility, and knowledge production across time and space. The analysis of this paper highlights how Participatory Design, when mediated through artifacts such as toolkits and workbooks, can both enable and constrain engagement, shaping power dynamics and the ethics of care in distributed collaboration. The discussion critically examines how delegation impacts environmental justice, counter-narratives, and *infrastructuring,* raising questions about the unseen labour of participation, the risks of reinforcing existing knowledge hierarchies, and the potential for new relationalities in asynchronous collaboration.

INTRODUCTION

Participatory design has traditionally been understood as a *situated* (Haraway, 1988), real-time practice grounded in direct collaboration between designers and participants. While this perspective does not exclude the possibility of remote participation, the field's origins in workplace democracy (Ehn, 1988; Bjerknes & Bratteteig, 1995) have fostered an enduring emphasis on long-term (Karasti, Baker & Millerand, 2010) co-presence, dialogue, and hands-on engagement. These elements are seen as essential for generating shared knowledge, negotiating meaning, and co-creating interventions (Binder et al., 2011; Hillgren et al., 2025). However, contemporary participatory processes increasingly rely on asynchronous and delegated participation, distributing design work across time and space (Sharma, 2021; Horváth et al., 2022; Lachance, 2021). A critical and growing body of scholars from a range of scholarships are concerned with the implications of distributed cognition, from educational context to more-than-human geographies, connecting to discourses around care and entanglement. This shift raises fundamental ethical and political questions: Who carries the burden of participation? How does asynchronous engagement reshape agency and responsibility? What forms of knowledge and action become possible—or impossible—when design is structured as an ongoing, self-directed task rather than an immediate, co-present exchange?

This paper refers to this delegation of responsibility as *homework*—design work that participants undertake independently, beyond the spatial and temporal boundaries of the workshop or design lab. The paper follows two case-studies where toolkits and workbooks (respectively) have been developed though participatory design to follow the negotiation of labour distribution in the design process and explore the political and ethical implications of design as homework within the broader discourse of relational design.

Participatory design has long emphasized *situated* knowledge production understanding knowledge as embedded in material and social contexts (Suchman, 2002). As participatory design increasingly extends

beyond the immediate, facilitated moment, it shifts from directly negotiated engagement toward distributed, asynchronous participation—a transformation that has consequences for care, justice, and counter-narratives in design practice.

This paper argues that participatory design, when mediated through homework, is undergoing a structural shift that reshapes labours of care (Smedberg, 2022). While this shift may expand access, allowing participation on one's own terms, it also redistributes cognitive, emotional, and logistical labor in ways that may not be equitable. This shift aligns with broader debates on delegation and *infrastructuring*—how systems distribute action across time and space, embedding values, assumptions, and limitations into participatory processes (Star & Ruhleder, 1996; Marres, 2012). As Susan Leigh Star (1991) points out, when the norms of infrastructure become fixed, they can have ethical consequences for people who don't align with or are left out of these systems. These structures are also often tied up with habitual ways of thinking and acting that make them seem natural, which in turn makes them harder to question or change.

By framing participatory design as *homework*, this paper interrogates the ways in which design tools mediate relations, knowledge, and action in participatory processes.

The following sections analyze two case studies—a toolkit for activist self-organization and a workbook-based remote design process—to explore how homework functions in practice and what tensions and possibilities emerge in the process. Both case studies are ongoing, and the design processes they describe have not yet reached their final stages. As a result, the insights presented here focus on the development and unfolding of the design processes rather than their final deliverables. This is a deliberate choice, reflecting both an ethical commitment to the participants and the need to avoid premature disclosure of outcomes. In the second case study, this approach is particularly important, as the final design artefact—a toolkit for activist groups—will be formally published after this paper and the Nordes -25 conference.

FROM CO-PRESENCE TO HOMEWORK

The workshop has served as the canonical format for participatory encounters, a structured yet open-ended space where participants collectively negotiate design decisions, prototype solutions, and critically reflect on emerging practices (Sanders & Stappers, 2008). Central to this framing is the idea that design unfolds through direct engagement with materials, ideas, and one another, forming what Pelle Ehn (2008) describes as a "design-by-doing" approach. The immediacy of these encounters allows for embodied and experiential learning, where stakeholders' tacit knowledge is surfaced, and meaning is co-constructed in the moment. Additionally, participatory design has often drawn from anthropological and ethnographic traditions, emphasizing the importance of being embedded in the context of practice to ensure that design processes are both situated and meaningful (Suchman, 2002).

This emphasis on co-located, real-time participation is also rooted in an ethics of care and reciprocity (Light & Akama, 2014). The presence of facilitators and other participants is seen as crucial to supporting, scaffolding, and sharing responsibility in the design process. While power asymmetries are never fully erased, they are at least negotiated through direct interaction, allowing participants to push back, reinterpret, and co-shape the process in real time. In this sense, participatory design has traditionally been seen as a relational practice, dependent on proximate social and material engagements to produce just and meaningful outcomes.

However, as participatory design has expanded into geographically distributed collaborations, digital co-creation, and large-scale social innovation, this reliance on real-time, co-located engagement has been increasingly challenged.

CASE STUDY ONE: THE WORKBOOK-BASED REMOTE DESIGN PROCESS

The first case study, an ongoing project running from 2023 to 2026, explores climate adaptation in transport systems through a design-driven approach. The project is led by a team of three researchers—a participatory design specialist from Malmö University and two researchers from VTI with expertise in transport infrastructure and geology. This group collaborates with partners from four Swedish municipalities (Ystad, Halmstad, Lerum, Skellefteå) and one regional authority (Göteborgsregionen), each responsible for engaging local professionals and citizens.

The project began with an intensive two-day kickoff meeting, bringing together all participants in person to establish a shared understanding of the project's goals and methods. Since then, the participants have primarily worked in smaller, locally organized "nodes" consisting of 1–3 members each. These nodes are tasked not only with implementing the workbook exercises but also with acting as local facilitators, engaging their own networks of professionals, citizens, and stakeholders. In this sense, they have become their own participatory designers, responsible for extending the reach of the project within their local contexts.

The workbooks play a crucial role in this process, guiding each node through the double diamond model over several months. The first workbook, distributed at the start of the project, included four steps, each containing exercises like photo safaris, mapping, and cluster analysis. These exercises encouraged

participants to explore their local contexts and identify critical climate adaptation challenges. After completing this phase, the nodes reconvened to synthesize their findings and develop "How Might We" (HMW) questions that became the basis for the second phase. The second workbook, developed in response to participant feedback, offered more flexibility, acknowledging the participants' growing confidence as local facilitators. It included exercises like reversed brainstorming, Crazy Eights, and Round Robin brainstorming, providing participants with a range of tools for ideation. This iterative approach has enabled the participants to gradually develop their own facilitation skills, reflecting a shift from merely following instructions to actively shaping their local adaptation strategies.



Fig 1. Photograph depicting workbooks 1 and 2. Credits belong to the authors.

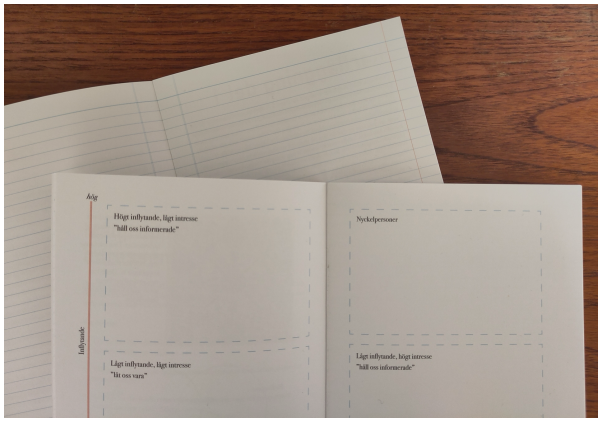


Fig 2. Photograph depicting sample pages from workbook 1 and workbook 2. Credits belong to the authors.

The project is expected to generate two key outcomes: (1) a process tool for spatial planning to enhance cross-sector collaboration, and (2) policy recommendations for refining legal and regulatory frameworks related to climate adaptation. Additionally, the project aims to strengthen inter-municipal and cross-organizational cooperation, laying the groundwork for long-term systemic change**.**

This case study explores how a structured yet distributed participatory design process can facilitate climate adaptation planning across multiple municipalities. The method employed—centered on workbooks guiding participants through a double diamond process—structures participation by providing a clear yet flexible framework. By distributing engagement across different geographical nodes, the project ensures that stakeholders remain actively involved in their own contexts rather than being drawn into a centralized, one-size-fits-all process.

The project also highlights differences between mediated and co-located engagement. The use of workbooks as structured guides represents a form of mediated participation, where knowledge flows are scaffolded by pre-designed steps rather than emerging organically through face-to-face interaction. Some of the participants responded positively to this mediation, finding comfort in the staked-out path. In particular, those who operated in heavily top-down and hierarchical organizations witnessed that the mediated engagements offered an excuse to "venture outside the box" (Author's notes, 2024). Additionally, the mediated approach ensured consistency across nodes and required participants to navigate uncertainties and interpretations individually before converging for collective discussions. By contrast, co-located engagements—such as the periodic in-person meetings—functioned as synchronization points where dispersed experiences could be consolidated, misunderstandings addressed, and new trajectories collectively shaped.

Ultimately, the method underscores the tension between structure and flexibility in participatory design when self-guided materials to structure engagement replace the synchronous workshop format (Teli, Bødker & al., 2020) Rather than being facilitated in real time, participatory engagement is now often scripted into materials, templates, and interfaces, distributing the work of participation across different times and spaces. The work of scripting is passed on to the participants. This delegation is not neutral—it embeds values, assumptions, and constraints into the process, shaping not only how participants contribute but also what forms of participation are considered valid or legible (Star, 1991).

Latour's (1999) concept of circulating reference offers a useful lens through which to understand how participatory work is distributed and mediated in these processes. Originally used to describe how scientific knowledge moves from the field to inscriptions, translating material observations into textual or graphical representations, circulating reference helps us understand how participation in design is displaced, reinterpreted, and reconstituted through artifacts. In the case of workbook-based participation, the workbooks function as a *chain of translations*—moving ideas from researchers to municipal stakeholders, and from

stakeholders to their local communities. Each step in this process involves a transformation, where the meaning of participation is subtly altered depending on the material constraints and interpretive frames of those engaging with the tool.

Unlike in co-present workshops, where misunderstandings can be addressed in real time and the trajectory of design work negotiated collectively, workbook-mediated participation relies on iterative reinterpretation without immediate feedback loops. The workbooks serve as stabilizing devices, but also as filters—certain voices, concerns, and interpretations become reinforced, while others fade into the background. As a result, the knowledge produced through this process is contingent on how well the embedded scripts align with the realities of those implementing them. If the assumptions guiding the workbooks do not correspond to local needs, the intended participatory work may be misinterpreted, diluted, or abandoned altogether.

This resonates with broader critiques of delegation in participatory design. When participation is structured through artifacts rather than direct engagement, the politics of interpretation come to the fore: who defines the reference points, who stabilizes meaning, and who is responsible when participation fails to align with its intended goals? In this case study it was the participants who sought and found affinities with other participants – and used the workbook to do so – who fared the best. But there were also those who used the mediating presence of the workbook as an excuse to not engage with others. Design studies scholars have pointed to similar dynamics in the increasing use of toolkits and frameworks to guide participatory practices. Sanders and Stappers (2014) discuss how design toolkits offer a form of "scaffolding" for creativity, structuring participants' engagement through predefined prompts, categories, and materials. However, while toolkits and other self-guided methods broaden the scope of participation by allowing engagement beyond the immediate presence of a facilitator, they also introduce new forms of control and constraint. The openness and adaptability of real-time co-design are replaced by a pre-structured, often linear set of tasks that participants are expected to complete on their own.

This shift—from co-presence to homework—raises significant political and ethical concerns. When design participation becomes an individual task rather than a shared, supported process, the burden of engagement shifts accordingly. What forms of labour become invisible in this transformation? Who has the time, resources, or confidence to participate meaningfully under these conditions? Interestingly, the participants who found connection and momentum through the workbook were also those already familiar with innovation practices—one even jokingly described herself as "fluent in workshop" (Author's notes, 2024). If the difference between participants had been one of language fluency rather than familiarity with design methods, we might more easily recognize the unequal thresholds for participation—and the implicit exclusions that follow.

CASE STUDY TWO: THE DEVELOPMENT OF THE ACTIVISTS' TOOLKIT

While the first case study involved researcher–public sector–citizen dynamics, this second case study focuses on an activist-to-activist toolkit—a deck of cards designed to help grassroots movements self-organize political campaigns. Here, participation was peer-driven rather than mediated by researchers or institutions, making it relevant for analysing work and action in participatory design. Methodologically, this study draws on participant observation and qualitative reflections during four workshops held over the course of a year.

The activist toolkit is currently being developed through a participatory design process initiated by the Zetkin Foundation, a non-profit organization based in Malmö. The foundation is affiliated with the Swedish Left Party but also supports trade unions and activist groups worldwide with digital infrastructure for political organizing. Despite the availability of these technological tools, the foundation recognized that activists often lacked strategies and structures for organizing and mobilizing, prompting the need for a practical resource that could guide strategic thinking and action. Rather than offering a predefined technological solution, the aim of the toolkit is to provide a flexible framework for strategic thinking, enabling activists to analyse power dynamics, plan actions, and build campaigns (cf. McAlevey, 2016).

Zetkin Foundation invited activists from Sweden and Denmark, including members of both the Swedish and Danish Left Parties, as well as environmental groups, labour unions, and tenant associations. This assembly embraced a co-creative process to foster collective learning among participants. The meetings were more than just design sessions; they were pedagogical spaces where activists could refine their skills and deepen their understanding of organizing principles.

Over the course of about eight months, the project unfolded through regular, bi-monthly meetings, each serving as a synchronization point to test, refine, and discuss ideas. For example, in one of the initial workshops, the group explored different game formats to identify structures that could guide activist strategy. Participants tried out various prototypes, reflecting on their own organizing practices as they played, and speculated about how these tools might be used by other activist groups. This process of "speculative

prototyping" provided a valuable medium for exchanging experiences, as the group shared not just their hopes for the toolkit but also their own organizing tactics. This kind of reflection, where participants collectively imagine future uses, is a form of shared knowledge production that is rarely given space in everyday organizing, where the pressures of immediate action often take precedence over long-term strategy.



Fig 3. Photograph from a workshop on game format affordances, autumn 2023. Credit belongs to the authors.

Importantly, the card deck also became a medium for building new relationships and strengthening transnational networks. To paraphrase one participant from the Danish Left Party in Copenhagen during one of the closing reflections *"Now, when I speak to* [activists in Malmö], *I feel like we're not just allies, but part of the same movement."* (Author's notes, 2023). This kind of relational design, where the process of creating tools becomes a way to build solidarity, highlights the importance of fostering connections that extend beyond the immediate goals of a single project.

The activist toolkit provides valuable insights into infrastructuring as a distributed, ongoing, and activist-driven process rather than a top-down intervention. Instead of simply providing activists with a predefined technological infrastructure, Zetkin Foundation recognized the need for a cognitive infrastructure—a shared way of thinking about organizing. The deck of cards functioned not just as a tool but as a generative structure for embedding organizing principles, fostering collective learning, and shaping activist practice over time.

The group did not begin the process knowing that a deck of cards would be the outcome. Instead, the format emerged gradually as participants co-designed both the tools and the processes needed to use them effectively. The lessons captured in the final toolkit, therefore, reflect not just the formal content of the workshops but also the lived experiences and evolving strategies of the participants themselves. In this sense, the group "built the bridge as they walked it," drawing on their collective experiences to shape a resource that is both adaptable and deeply rooted in activist practice.

This second case study, then, underscores the relational nature of participatory design, not just in terms of creating tools for action, but also in the ways these tools can act as nodes in a broader network of political practice. By fostering connections across geographic and organizational boundaries, the toolkit aims to cultivate not just effective organizing, but also a sense of shared purpose and mutual support among activists.

Returning to Latour's (1999) concept of circulating reference we see how the activist toolkit is not just as a static object but as a dynamic mediator of meaning, transforming as it moves between different contexts of use. The toolkit originated within a small, co-located group of activists, but its intended impact extended far beyond them, into a distributed network of asynchronous users. Like Latour's example of how scientific knowledge is transformed through inscriptions at different stages—where observations in the field become standardized data in a lab, then abstracted into theory—the toolkit underwent a similar chain of translation. And, like Latour's example, the toolkit begs the question "How do we pack the world into words?" (Latour, 1999, p.24).

Initially, the ideas and organizing methods embedded in the toolkit were co-developed through dialogue and iteration. However, once the product was finished it would have to function autonomously, carrying the traces of its design process while also being interpreted and recontextualized by new users. Activists receiving the toolkit were not encouraged to engage with the original co-designers; rather, they encountered a structured representation of activist knowledge, a fixed inscription of methods meant to be universally applicable. The design of the toolkit was, on the other hand, made in such a way that the receiving activists could continue develop the digital archive that the deck of cards corresponded to, a kind of design-after-design (Ehn, 2008).

This highlights a fundamental tension: Does the toolkit enable decentralized agency, or does it impose a static framework onto inherently situated struggles? The risk of circulating reference, as Latour warns, is that each new layer of interpretation transforms the original meaning—potentially losing the fluid, context-sensitive strategies of activism in favour of rigid, formalized instructions. If participatory design is increasingly structured through homework, then artifacts such as toolkits, workbooks, and digital platforms become

central mediators of the design process. These artifacts are shaping both how and what participants contribute. For example, design toolkits (Sanders & Stappers, 2014) are often presented as ways to democratize design by giving non-designers structured means to engage in creative exploration. However, toolkits also introduce predefined categories, prompts, and structures that can limit the openness of participation, steering engagement toward ways of knowing and doing. Similarly, workbooks that guide participants through a double diamond process (as the one in case study one, above) frame design as a linear and staged endeavour, potentially constraining the kinds of emergent, situated knowledge that might arise in more fluid, dialogical settings.

Rather than seeing homework as merely a pragmatic solution to logistical challenges, this paper argues that it should be understood as a *site of contestation* (Suchman, 2002*)*—a moment where the politics of participation are reconfigured through delegation. While structuring participatory design through homework can enable broader accessibility and sustained engagement over time, it also risks shifting responsibility onto participants in ways that are unequally distributed and often unaccounted for in the design process.

A SUMMARY OF BOTH CASE STUDIES

The two cases share a commitment to participatory design but diverge significantly in how they structure participation, distribute agency, and mediate engagement through artifacts. They reveal different strategies for infrastructuring participatory work—one through a collaboratively designed toolkit and the other through structured workbooks guiding a multi-nodal process.

The first case study highlights a fundamental tension in delegating participation: Does the toolkit enable decentralized agency, or does it impose a static framework onto inherently situated struggles? These cases reveal that structuring participation asynchronously and at a distance transforms agency, responsibility, and power in ways that warrant deeper interrogation. The second case study raises questions about the politics of interpretation in distributed participation: when engagement is mediated through artifacts rather than direct interaction, who defines the reference points, who stabilizes meaning, and who is accountable when participation fails to align with its intended goals? The following discussion unpacks these themes by situating them within broader debates on relational design, infrastructuring, and the ethics of distributed participation.

STRUCTURING PARTICIPATION ACROSS SITES

A key tension that emerges from the case studies is how participation is structured across sites—both in terms of time and space. The activist toolkit case relied on iterative co-creation, where a core group engaged in recurring meetings but had agency over how and when to engage between sessions. In contrast, the climate adaptation case was highly structured and sequential, requiring participants to progress through predefined steps at set intervals. While this ensured consistency across municipalities, it also limited flexibility and left participants with less control over the process.

Spatially, these cases differed in how responsibility was distributed. The activist toolkit was developed centrally, with a small group shaping its content before distribution to a broader activist network. The climate adaptation case, on the other hand, was explicitly decentralized, requiring participants in different municipalities to work locally and engage their own communities. This fragmentation increased complexity in maintaining coherence across nodes and highlighted the challenges of delegation and accountability in long-term participatory processes.

DELEGATION, RESPONSIBILITY, AND POLITICAL AGENCY

Both cases reflect the politics of delegation in participatory design. Case study two placed the burden of interpretation on future users—while the co-designers produced the toolkit, it was up to activist groups to make sense of and apply its methods. This was a bottom-up model of delegation, granting users the flexibility to adapt the toolkit to their specific needs.

By contrast, case study one explicitly delegated authority to municipal actors, instructing them to implement participatory processes within their local contexts. This top-down delegation ensured adherence to a shared methodology but also constrained how participation unfolded. The difference here is one of openness versus prescription—while the activist toolkit was meant to be reinterpreted, the workbooks scripted engagement, guiding participants toward predetermined outcomes.

This contrast foregrounds an essential issue in participatory design: Does structuring participation through artifacts support decentralized agency, or does it impose static frameworks onto situated struggles? The activist toolkit sought to empower users by offering an open-ended resource, while the workbooks aimed to coordinate participation at scale, ensuring structured engagement. Both approaches have trade-offs—one prioritizing adaptability, the other ensuring coherence—but they highlight the tension between agency and control in infrastructuring participation.

TEMPORALITY AND THE BURDENS OF ASYNCHRONOUS PARTICIPATION

Both cases illustrate how participatory design, when structured as homework, demands sustained engagement over time. In the activist toolkit case, this took the form of continuous iteration—participants engaged in cycles of development, testing, and refinement. In contrast, the climate adaptation case relied on asynchronous engagement, where knowledge was distributed across different nodes and synthesized during periodic meetings.

One of the most pronounced challenges in the climate adaptation case was maintaining participatory momentum—especially when participants were expected to contribute across working groups outside of formal sessions. This underscores a core issue in asynchronous participation: the invisible labour of sustaining engagement beyond structured moments of interaction. Without the reinforcing dynamics of co-located collaboration, individuals must take on greater cognitive and logistical responsibility to self-direct their involvement.

As Susan Leigh Star (1991) reminds us, when infrastructural norms become fixed, they carry ethical consequences—particularly for those who don't align with or are excluded by the systems in place. These structures often become entangled with dominant ways of thinking and acting, which naturalize them and make them difficult to question. In the context of participatory design, the assumed desirability of connection, collaboration, and shared responsibility can itself become a normative structure—one that not all actors wish to inhabit. Some participants may actively resist relation, embracing instead a "desire for nonrelation" (Ginn, 2014, p.538) or "hoped-for absence." (ibid.) In the activist toolkit case, this surfaced through participants who rejected the invitation to find affinities (Giraud, 2019), instead maintaining protective distances as a political stance.

Recognizing these refusals as intentional—and at times necessary—reminds us that participatory design must grapple not only with who *can* participate, but also with who *wants* to, and on what terms. Otherwise, the infrastructures we build risk reproducing the very exclusions and erasures they seek to challenge.

THE ROLE OF ARTIFACTS IN MEDIATING PARTICIPATION

The role of artifacts—whether toolkits or workbooks—was central in shaping how participation unfolded in both cases. The activist toolkit functioned as a generative resource, allowing activists to experiment with different strategies and adapt organizing methods to their own contexts. The workbooks, in contrast, acted as prescriptive guides, structuring participation through a sequenced process with defined checkpoints.

This contrast illustrates a broader question in participatory design: To what extent should infrastructuring enable open-ended co-creation versus providing structured pathways for engagement? While the activist toolkit fostered bottom-up engagement, the workbooks facilitated top-down coordination across a fragmented stakeholder landscape. These differences underscore how artifacts are not neutral; they mediate agency, structure participation, and shape whose knowledge is legitimized in participatory processes.

DISCUSSION: STEWARDING CARE AND JUSTICE IN DISTRIBUTED PARTICIPATION

The methodological choices in both case studies foreground critical questions about care and justice in participatory design, particularly within distributed and asynchronous modes of engagement. The Relational Design perspective asks us to attend to ontological multiplicity, working with tensions, paradoxes, and linkages. In our cases, the structured participation of homework—through workbooks and locally mediated processes—created distinct forms of relationality that shaped both knowledge production and power dynamics.

On one hand, this structured engagement enabled participants to work with site-specific conditions, fostering local ownership and facilitating knowledge flows that may not have emerged in centrally orchestrated workshops alone. The workbook format, reminiscent of school exercises, provided a scaffold for engagement while allowing for contextual adaptation. However, this structure also constrained participation by requiring individuals to carry responsibilities beyond the facilitated moments of collective engagement. The delegation of design work into everyday spaces—outside of co-located workshops—raises questions about who bears the cognitive, affective, and logistical burdens of participation?

From an ethics of care perspective, the asynchronous nature of participation required participants to navigate relationships with others in their own networks, often without direct facilitation. This distributed labor had unintended consequences: some participants found new capacities for civic engagement, while others struggled with isolation, lack of clarity, or conflicting demands. Thus, the process simultaneously fostered new literacies of participation and surfaced existing inequities in how care and responsibility are distributed. This highlights a core concern within relational design: how to steward just and viable participatory processes without reproducing the very exclusions they seek to address.

Digital participation has at times been celebrated as an antidote to the centration of participation around populated areas, and in particular affluent areas. The

possibility of engaging with people outside the cities, on the countryside, or people in other countries does at a first glance seem to be a cultivation of pluralistic perspectives. Yet, in our cases, homework as a mode of participation had ambivalent effects on these aspirations. In theory, decentralizing participation by delegating tasks to local nodes could be seen as redistributing agency. However, the actual practice of distributed engagement revealed persistent asymmetries. Participants in different locations had uneven access to resources, expertise, and institutional backing, leading to disparities in what forms of knowledge were legitimized. Some municipal actors had prior experience with collaborative planning, while others lacked the institutional culture to support such work. This raises the question: does structuring participation as homework truly decentralize power, or does it inadvertently co-opt attempts at decolonization or decentralisation? As many scholars have noted before, there is a devastating power in placating a political need with formalities: 'the currency of the term "decolonizing" being reduced to a hollow gesture' (Schultz et al, 2018., p.84). And the labour of maintaining the formalities often fall on those with the most marginalised voices. Sara Ahmed reflects on how institutional expectations around diversity work tend to unevenly burden those who are already marked as "different" within the organization. She uses the term "nots" to describe how people are often positioned in terms of what they are *not*: not white, not male, not straight, not able-bodied—and how this accumulation of "nots" becomes a form of institutional labour. As she writes:

"*The more nots you are, the more committees you might end up on. Not being not can mean being less likely to end up doing this kind of work. Given that diversity work is typically less valued by organizations, then not being not can mean having more time to do more-valued work.*" (Ahmed, 2017., p.135)

The delegation of participatory labour risks *invisibilizing* certain forms of work and responsibility and makes the kind of delegation that Ahmed speaks of less easy to spot. The expectation that participants engage asynchronously meant that some individuals took on significant organizing and interpretive work, while others remained more passive. This echoes broader concerns in participatory design about the unseen labour that underpins collaboration—who does the work, who benefits, and whose contributions are made visible?

CONCLUSION: RETHINKING PARTICIPATION BEYOND THE WORKSHOP

Taken together, these two cases highlight how participatory design is reconfigured when structured as homework. While asynchronous participation can extend engagement beyond the temporal and spatial boundaries of co-located workshops, it also redistributes labour and responsibility in ways that create new challenges. Homework requires participants to self-direct their involvement, interpret design materials independently, and sustain participation over time—raising important questions about care, accountability, and agency.

These shifts illuminate a broader set of tensions at the heart of relational design. Participation is not simply a matter of extending opportunities for engagement, but of negotiating the terms under which relationships are built, deferred, or refused. As seen in the activist toolkit case, not all actors desire connection; some maintain a "hoped-for absence" (Ginn, 2014), exercising a refusal to relate as a form of political or affective protection (Giraud, 2019). Such stances challenge the often-unquestioned assumption that more participation—or more relation—is inherently better. If relational design is to remain attentive to difference, it must account for both the possibility and the limits of relation.

As Susan Leigh Star (1991) reminds us, infrastructures solidify normative assumptions that may exclude or disadvantage those who do not easily align with dominant systems. Asynchronous infrastructures, in particular, risk naturalizing individualized participation as a neutral good, obscuring the labour, capacities, and power dynamics involved. Returning to Latour's (1999) notion of *circulating reference*, we might say that as participation travels—dispersed across actors, tasks, and tools—it becomes vulnerable to slippages, frictions, and losses. What holds a participatory process together when co-presence is removed? And what relational work becomes invisible in its absence?

To navigate these challenges, participatory design must remain critically attuned to the politics of delegation, the ethical limits of infrastructuring, and the risks of invisibilized labour. Designing infrastructures that support distributed agency is not merely a technical challenge, but a justice-oriented one. It demands a shift away from participation-as-inclusion and toward an engagement with the uneven, situated, and sometimes oppositional conditions under which participation unfolds. This includes recognizing when participation is not possible, not desirable, or not safe—and ensuring that the design of relation makes space for refusal as well as connection.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

We would like to thank Gunnel Göransson and the PolKat project for their generous support and collaboration throughout this research. We are also grateful to Richard Olsson at the Zetkin Foundation for his valuable feedback on earlier drafts of this paper. Finally, our deepest thanks go to the participants in both

projects, whose time, insights, and commitment made this work possible.

REFERENCES

Ahmed, S. (2017) *Living a feminist life.* Duke University Press.

Binder, T., De Michelis, G., Ehn, P., Jacucci, G., & Linde, P. (2011). *Design things*. MIT press.

Bjerknes, G., & Bratteteig, T. (1995). User participation and democracy: A discussion of Scandinavian research on system development. *Scandinavian Journal of information systems*, *7*(1), 1.

Ehn, P. (1988). *Work-oriented design of computer artifacts* (Doctoral dissertation, Arbetslivscentrum).

Ehn, P. (2008). Participation in design things. In *Participatory Design Conference (PDC), Bloomington, Indiana, USA (2008)* (pp. 92-101). ACM Digital Library.

Ginn, F. (2014). Sticky lives: Slugs, detachment and more-than-human ethics in the garden. *Transactions of the Institute of British Geographers*, *39*(4), 532-544.

Giraud, E. H. (2019). *What comes after entanglement?: Activism, anthropocentrism, and an ethics of exclusion*. Duke University Press.

Haraway, D. (1988). Situated knowledges: The science question in feminism and the privilege of partial perspective 1. In *Women, science, and technology* (pp. 455-472). Routledge.

Hillgren, P. A., Linde, P., Smedberg, A., Nilsson, E. M., Ehn, P., & Eriksen, M. A. (2025). Living Labs for Open-Ended Participatory Design. In *Routledge International Handbook of Contemporary Participatory Design* (pp. 259-271). Routledge.

Horváth, D., Ásványi, K., Cosovan, A., Csordás, T., Faludi, J., Galla, D., ... & Simay, A. E. (2022). Online only: Future outlooks of post-pandemic education based on student experiences of the virtual university. *Society and Economy*, *44*(1), 2-21.

Karasti, H., Baker, K. S., & Millerand, F. (2010). Infrastructure time: Long-term matters in collaborative development. *Computer Supported Cooperative Work (CSCW)*, *19*, 377-415.

Lachance, E. L. (2021). COVID-19 and its impact on volunteering: Moving towards virtual volunteering. *Leisure Sciences*, *43*(1-2), 104-110.

Latour, B. (1999). *Pandora's hope*. Cambridge: Harvard University Press.

Light, A., & Akama, Y. (2014, October). Structuring future social relations: the politics of care in participatory practice. In *Proceedings of the 13th Participatory Design Conference: Research Papers-Volume 1* (pp. 151-160).

McAlevey, J. F. (2016). *No shortcuts: Organizing for power in the new gilded age*. Oxford University Press.

Marres, N. (2012). The redistribution of methods: on intervention in digital social research, broadly conceived. *The sociological review*, *60*(1_suppl), 139-165.

Sanders, E. B. N., & Stappers, P. J. (2008). Co-creation and the new landscapes of design. *Co-design*, *4*(1), 5-18.

Sanders, E. B. N., & Stappers, P. J. (2014). Probes, toolkits and prototypes: three approaches to making in codesigning. *CoDesign*, *10*(1), 5-14.

Sharma, D. (2021). The world of virtual conferencing: is the pandemic paving the path?. *Journal of Neurosurgical Anesthesiology*, *33*(1), 7-9.

Schultz, T., Abdulla, D., Ansari, A., Canlı, E., Keshavarz, M., Kiem, M., ... & JS Vieira de Oliveira, P. (2018). What is at stake with decolonizing design? A roundtable. *Design and Culture*, *10*(1), 81-101.

Smedberg, A. (2022). *The labour of infrastructuring: An inquiry into participatory design in the public sector* (Doctoral dissertation, Malmö University Press).

Star, S. L. (1991). Power, technology and the phenomenology of conventions: on being allergic to onions. *The Sociological Review*, *38*(1_suppl), 26-56.

Star, S. L., & Ruhleder, K. (2016). 20 Steps toward an Ecology of Infrastructure: Design and Access for Large Information Spaces. *Boundary Objects and Beyond: Working with Leigh Star*, 377.

Suchman, L. (2002). Located accountabilities in technology production. *Scandinavian journal of information systems*, *14*(2), 7.

Teli, M., Foth, M., Sciannamblo, M., Anastasiu, I., & Lyle, P. (2020, June). Tales of institutioning and commoning: Participatory design processes with a strategic and tactical perspective. In *Proceedings of the 16th Participatory Design Conference 2020-Participation (s) Otherwise-Volume 1* (pp. 159-171